PRODUCT DESIGN PORTFOLIO · 2026

Dharmarao Balaga

Senior / Principal Product Designer · UX Strategy · AI-Enabled Product Design



From visual storytelling to product strategy — designing for people since 2001.

M.Des, IIT Bombay
Animation & Film

Head of Product Design
7 yrs · Openplay (Nazara)

Founder
D'SARAS Design Studio

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Hyderabad, India

WHY I'M DIFFERENT

Four chapters that make one product designer

01

Storyteller

2001 – 2014

M.Des in Animation & Film from IIT Bombay; 13 years as illustrator, animator and team lead.

I design flows the way I once paced films: sequence, clarity, emotion.

02

Design leader

2014 – 2025

Design Manager at Adeon, then 7 years as Head of Product Design at Openplay (Nazara Group).

Built and mentored a multidisciplinary team and set design standards across products.

03

Product shipper

2018 · 2026

Classic Rummy shipped on Android & iOS in 2018; TWAM went live on Google Play in June 2026.

End-to-end ownership: research, IA, interaction, UI, design system, handoff.

04

AI practitioner

2025 – today

Founder of D'SARAS Design Studio, running an AI-assisted design practice.

AI widens the exploration. The problem framing and final decisions stay mine.

The result: a designer who connects user needs, business goals and technology — and can show the reasoning behind every screen.

MY PROFESSIONAL JOURNEY

From visual storytelling to product innovation

2001 – 2014

Foundations

Illustrator → Graphic Designer → Animator → Team Lead

Color Chips · Globarena · Polygon Studios · The Boston Group · Helix · Esya · Cordys

Visual communication · Animation

2014 – 2018

Design Manager / Creative Head

Adeon Media Technologies

UX/UI and creative direction for enterprise & consumer web and mobile, incl. client brand Frodoe

UX/UI · Team leadership

2018 – 2025

Head of Product Design

Openplay Technologies (Nazara Games)

Led Classic Rummy from Flash to native mobile; design standards & systems; built and mentored the team

Product strategy · Design systems

2025 – today

Founder & Principal Product Designer

D'SARAS Design Studio

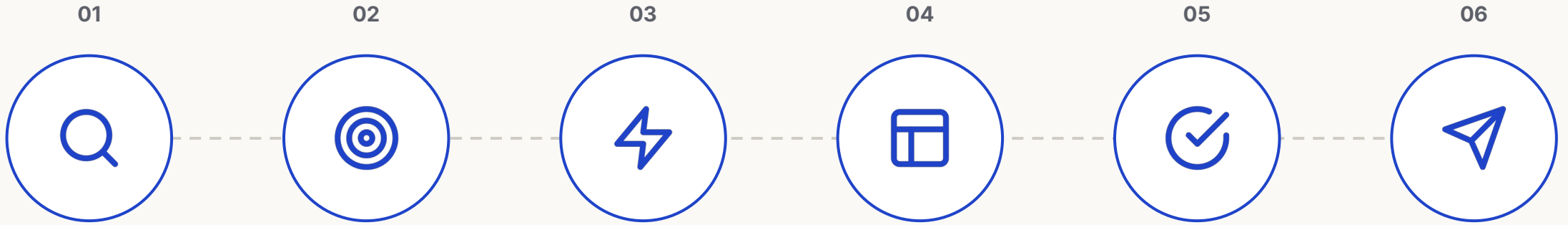
Product design consulting, TWAM, the DSDS design system, DesignAcharya, AI-assisted workflows

AI-enabled product design

Education **Master of Design (M.Des), Animation & Film — IIT Bombay** · Bachelor of Fine Arts, Applied Arts — JNAFAU, Hyderabad

HOW I WORK

One approach, proven on real products



01	02	03	04	05	06
Discover	**Define**	**Ideate**	**Design**	**Validate**	**Deliver**
Player interviews, 2 surveys and a 5-app competitive audit (Classic Rummy)	Two personas became two doors into one lobby; “How might we…” framing	Dial picker vs. real table list; 3 AI placements compared (ResolveAI)	IA, flows, UI kit and tokens; 20+ TWAM screens on one design system	Post-MVP usability study with task tests; WCAG contrast checks	Dev handoff and optimised assets; TWAM live on Google Play

Every decision is weighed on three axes: **User value × Business value × Technical feasibility**

FEATURED CASE STUDY 01 · OPENPLAY TECHNOLOGIES (NAZARA GROUP)

Rebuilding Classic Rummy for a mobile-first India

THE PROBLEM

In 2018 Chrome began phasing out Flash, and Classic Rummy's entire web platform was heading for obsolescence — putting accessibility, retention and device compatibility at risk at once.

> *How might we design an intuitive, engaging rummy app that works for both novice and expert players, and keeps gameplay seamless across devices?*

My role	Product design lead · end-to-end UX/UI ownership
Timeline	Feb – May 2018 · ~12 weeks
Platforms	Native Android, iOS and web
Worked with	Product, Engineering and QA
Status	Shipped 2018 · discontinued after India's 2025 ban on online money games



Players wanted less friction and more trust

Interviews with existing Flash players

Qualitative + quantitative surveys

Audit of 5 leading Indian rummy apps

CASUAL LEARNER

Vineet, 28 · Pune

"Will I be able to play this without prior experience? Is it safe to put my money here?"

Needs a pressure-free place to learn

→ Guided onboarding and a separate Practice door

COMPETITIVE REGULAR

Rajesh, 55 · Hyderabad

"I need smooth gameplay with no interruptions. Are my winnings secure?"

Needs speed and transparent prizes

→ One-tap competitive modes and live leaderboards

PLAYER SURVEY

85% preferred playing on a smartphone

85% found interactive tutorials helpful for learning rules

75% said tournaments & leaderboards are essential

The tension between relaxed learning and fast, high-stakes competition shaped almost every layout decision.

Five calls that shaped the product

1. **Two doors from one lobby**

   Practice for learners; Cash and Tournaments for regulars — both one tap from Home.

2. **Landscape to play, portrait for money**

   A 13-card hand needs width; forms read better upright. Switches only at flow boundaries.

3. **Real tables instead of a dial picker**

   Regulars choose by players, entry fee and status — filters removed a guess-then-wait step.

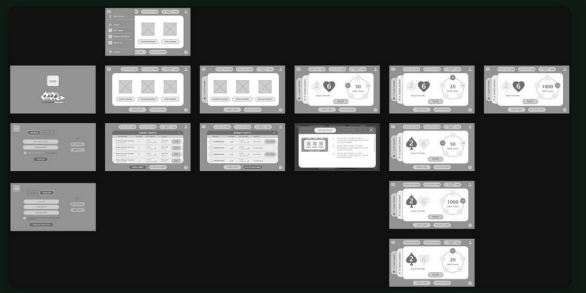
4. **Trust on the very first screen**

   Splash leads with withdrawals, secure payments, real players and RNG certification.

5. **Retention through progress, not pop-ups**

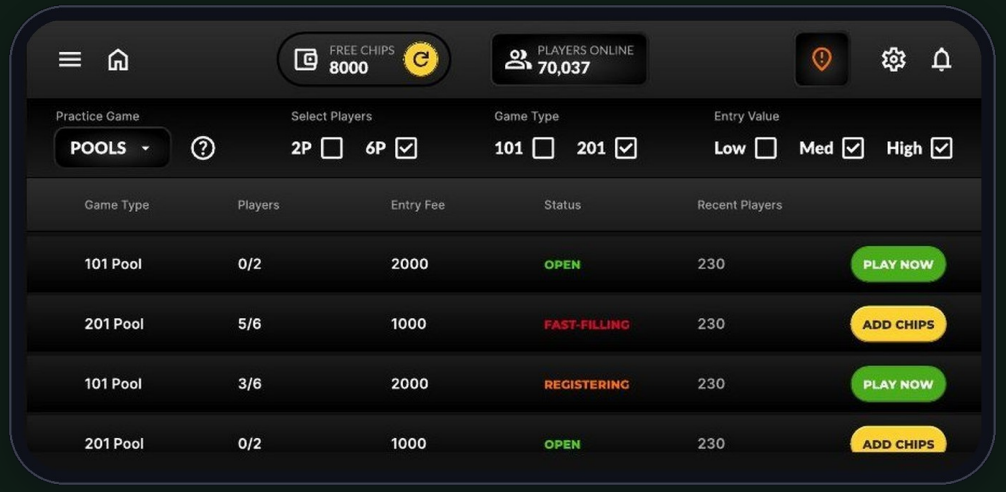
   A 7-day challenge, live leaderboards and table timers give reasons to return.

DECISION 3 — BEFORE



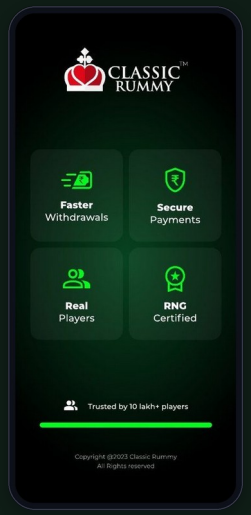
Early low-fi concepts used a playful dial to pick players and point value — but it hid the actual tables.

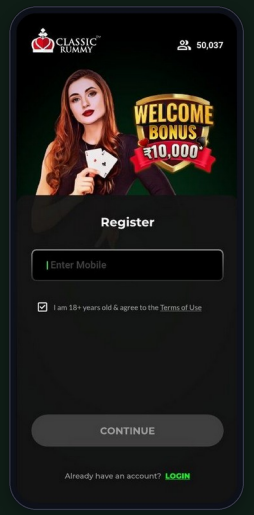
AFTER — SHIPPED



CLASSIC RUMMY · FINAL EXPERIENCE

Familiar felt-table green, modern clarity

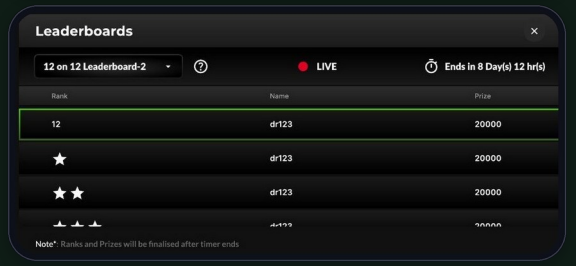












TESTED · POST-MVP

Usability study

Task-based tests and interviews, measuring completion rate and time-on-task.

ITERATED

Fixed what we found

Unclear scoring and missed challenges → in-context scoring help; challenges promoted on Home.

2026 PROPOSAL · NOT SHIPPED

The Practice door becomes the product

Rebuild it as a free-to-play social skill game with contextual rule hints.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Company results my work contributed to

2× **ROI**

Contributed to doubling ROI during the COVID-19 period

2× **Engagement**

Contributed to achieving 2x user engagement

Retention

Supported retention through UX and product improvements

Performance

Collaborated on game performance and loading speed

Early exploration: *AI-driven matchmaking was being explored — not shipped.*

FEATURED CASE STUDY 02 · ONLYTWAM · D'SARAS DESIGN STUDIO

TWAM: Reimagining Mobile Commerce Through AI-Augmented Product Design

THE DESIGN OPPORTUNITY

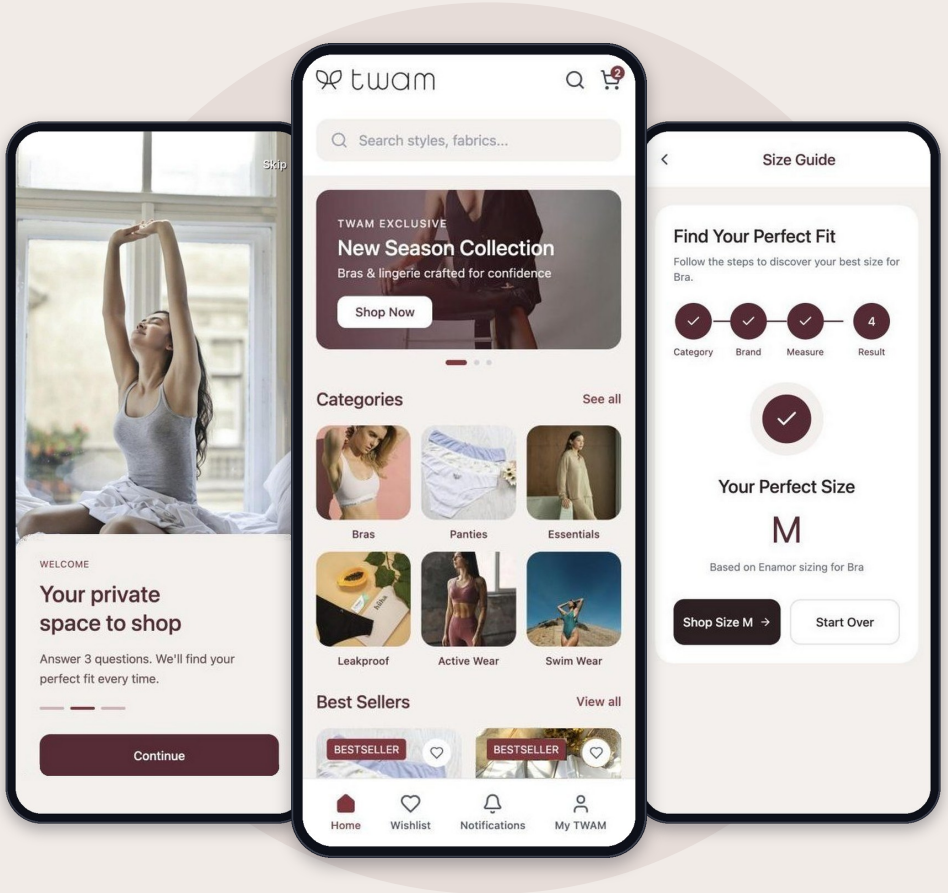
Shopping for intimate essentials involves more than product discovery. Customers need confidence in fit, privacy throughout the journey and a comfortable, discreet purchasing experience.

TWAM explores how a thoughtful mobile commerce experience can address these needs through guest browsing, personalised fit assistance and discreet purchasing.

HOW MIGHT WE

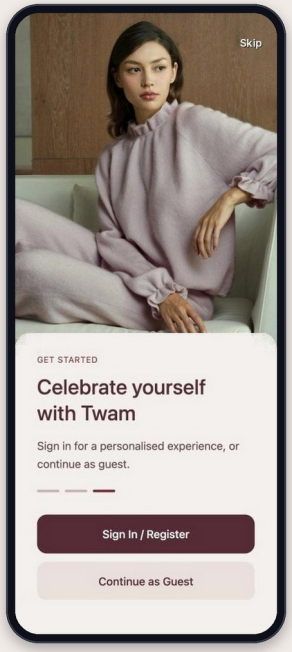
How might we create a comfortable, privacy-first shopping experience that helps customers discover the right products and make confident purchasing decisions?

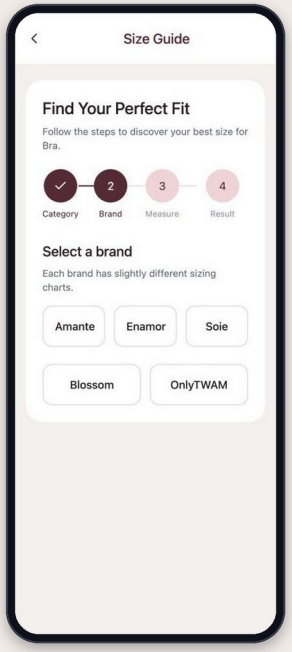
My role	Product Designer · Product Direction · UX Strategy · UI Design · AI-assisted Prototyping
Timeline	April – June 2026
AI technology	Claude · Figma Make AI · Figma
Design approach	AI-augmented product design and interactive prototyping
Status	**Shipped · live on Google Play since 20 June 2026**

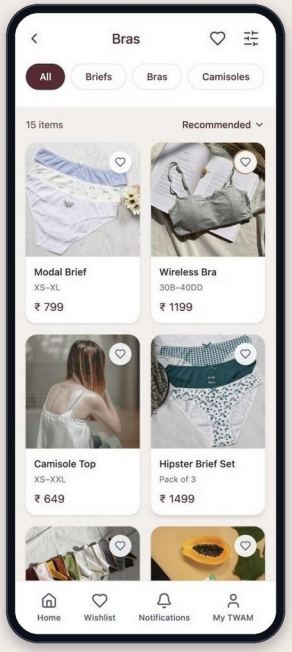


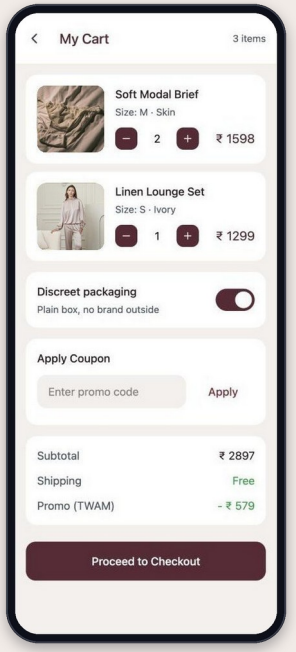
Five Experience Decisions That Shaped TWAM

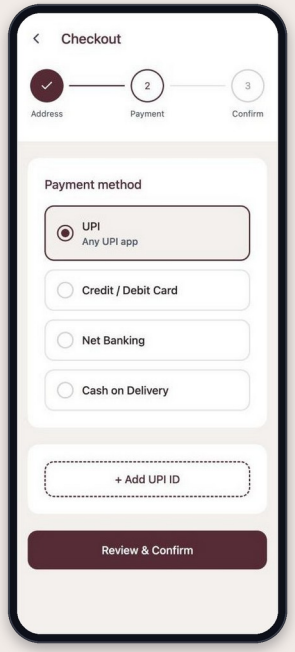
AI-assisted prototyping helped explore and refine the experience, while product decisions remained guided by user needs, usability and design judgement.











Guest browsing

Skip on every onboarding step; “Continue as Guest”.

Cost: personalisation starts later.

Fit from a known size

Pick a brand she wears and her size there — no tape measure.

Cost: only as good as brand size data.

Size range on cards

“XS–XL” or “30B–40DD” under each name.

Cost: ratings dropped from listing cards.

Discreet by default

“Plain box, no brand outside” — a cart toggle, on by default.

Cost: gives up a branded unboxing.

UPI first, COD kept

Three-step checkout opens on UPI; cash on delivery stays.

Cost: more cancellations and returns.

From Product Brief to Interactive Prototype — Powered by Figma Make AI

Exploring how emerging AI technologies can transform the product design and prototyping workflow.

	INITIAL PRODUCT DIRECTION		REFINED EXPERIENCE
Colour	Bright red visual direction (#D72229)	→	**Premium burgundy visual identity (#562C36)**
Surfaces	Warm ivory and blush surfaces (#FAF5F0)	→	**Soft greige and warm neutral surfaces (#F4F0ED)**
Navigation	Five-tab navigation	→	**Simplified four-tab navigation**
Fit help	Measurement-led fit assistance	→	**Fit assistance based on a familiar brand and size**
Experience	Initial product exploration	→	**More discreet and focused shopping experience**

> ***"The tools generated; I decided what stayed."***
>
> AI accelerated exploration and prototyping. Product direction, usability evaluation and final design decisions remained human-led.

Honest status: personas and insights came from desk research and are labelled hypotheses; launch metrics are not published.

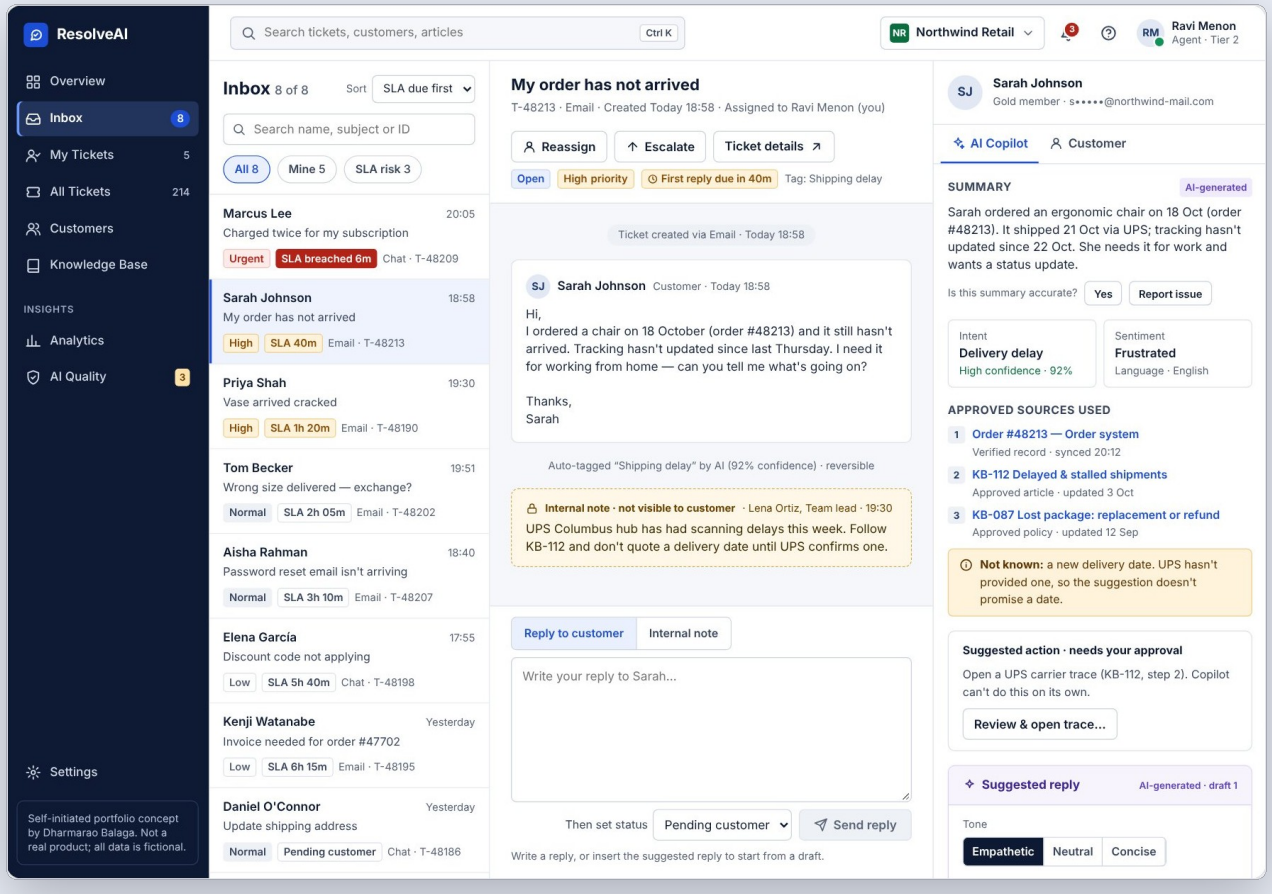
MY AI-ASSISTED WORKFLOW

1. **Product brief**
   Defined the product vision, experience principles and core requirements.
2. **AI-assisted exploration**
   Used Claude to explore concepts and translate written briefs into structured design directions.
3. **Figma Make AI prototyping**
   Used Figma Make AI to generate and iteratively develop the mobile app prototype.
4. **Designer-led refinement**
   Reviewed the generated experience, evaluated design decisions and refined the prototype through iterative experimentation.

135 SAVED VERSIONS · FIGMA MAKE AI

SUPPORTING CASE STUDY · SELF-INITIATED CONCEPT (2026) · NOT A SHIPPED PRODUCT

ResolveAI: AI that support agents can overrule



Built with Microsoft HAX guidelines, Google PAIR and WCAG 2.2 · every text pair ≥ 5.25:1 contrast

WHERE SHOULD THE AI LIVE?

A	**Auto-draft in the composer**	Fastest — but invites over-trust
B	**Side panel, explicit "Insert & edit"**	**Chosen: evidence beside the draft**
C	**Separate AI view**	Hides the thread while drafting

GUARDRAILS I DESIGNED

Cite or remove: every sentence carries a source; unsupported claims are struck through.

Review gate: Send stays disabled until an AI-assisted reply is reviewed.

Failure as a state: thin data or an outage never blocks the inbox.

All data is fictional. Hypotheses are defined and a test plan with 5–6 support agents is written — not yet run.

AI-POWERED PRODUCT DESIGN

AI accelerates my design. Judgement stays human.

01

Research synthesis

ChatGPT · Claude · Gemini

Cluster survey answers, draft affinity groups — then verify against raw quotes

02

Ideation & UX writing

Claude · ChatGPT · Gemini

Generate and compare more concepts before polishing any one

03

Rapid prototyping

Figma Make · Figma AI · Google Stitch

Shorten the path from a written brief to a working prototype

04

Visual & motion

Midjourney · Leonardo AI · Runway ML

Visual exploration, concept art and motion studies

Human gate at every step: I define the problem, evaluate trade-offs, ensure usability and make the final decision.

At Openplay

Introduced AI-assisted research and design workflows for the team.

At D'SARAS

Built a studio workflow with ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Figma Make and Stitch, used across client work.

In TWAM

Product brief → Claude-assisted exploration → Figma Make AI prototyping → 135 saved versions → Designer-led evaluation.

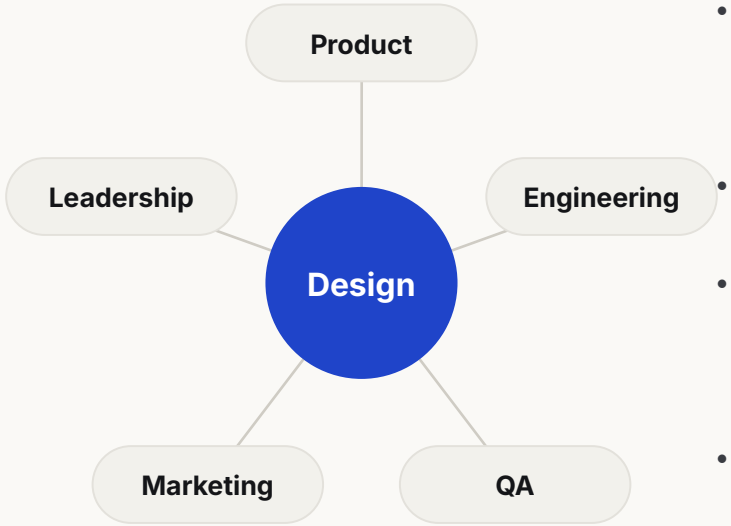
In ResolveAI

I wrote the brief and guardrail spec; AI produced screens; I reviewed every state against the spec.

LEADERSHIP & STUDIO

Leading design teams — and my own studio

HEAD OF PRODUCT DESIGN · OPENPLAY · 2018–2025



- Owned product design strategy and execution across gaming and digital products for 7 years
- Built, managed and mentored a multidisciplinary design team
- Set design standards and scalable design systems with Product, Engineering, Marketing and Leadership
- Used research and product insight to prioritise improvements

FOUNDER · D'SARAS DESIGN STUDIO · SINCE FEB 2025

A multi-wing studio: "Build better products. Grow faster. Train smarter."

Design

UX/UI, product design, mobile apps, design systems

Growth

Performance, SEO, CRO and funnels built on UX thinking

Academy

DesignAcharya — AI-era, Telugu–English design programme

Stories

2D animation, brand films and culturally rooted stories

Also built: the DSDS design system (tokens, wing themes, responsive patterns) and the studio's responsive website — dsaras.com.

WHAT I BRING TO YOUR TEAM

Let’s build products people understand and trust

Product thinking

Framing problems around users and business goals

End-to-end craft

Research, IA, interaction, UI, systems and handoff

Design leadership

7 years leading and mentoring a product design team

Practical AI

Faster exploration, with human judgement in charge

Open to Senior / Principal Product Designer, Product Design Lead and Design Manager roles — hybrid, onsite or remote.



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